In the Marvelous Dimension

By Kate Daniels

(Mary)

I picked the kids up

at 4:45, as usual.

As usual, they were antsy

and fighting. Rose tore a hole

in her new knee socks

kicking Justin in the backseat.

Timmy sucked his thumb in the corner.

Then Justin wailed at another

abuse from Rose and I was just about

to yell, ***Goddamnit, shut up for once,***

when the whole thing went. I mean

the whole thing, the whole world,

I thought.

INTRODUCTION

The San Francisco earthquake occurred on October 17, 1989, at 5:04 pm. It only lasted 15 seconds, but in that time the upper deck of the Nimitz Freeway collapsed, crushing vehicles and trapping their occupants. Mary and her children were on that freeway. This is their story.

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Excerpt from In the Marvelous Dimension by Kate Daniels

(Mary)

Goddamnit, shut up for once . . .

The car tilted, the road

buckled up and then something was falling

down on us with a horrible screaming.

I guess I stopped driving and turned

to my children with a face of horror.

I reached past the seatbelt for Timmy,

my baby, and that's when it hit us.

My hand, pressed by the roof, pinned

his leg to the seat and he screamed.

Blood flowed down. Rose, my sweet

little Rose, was already gone.

I couldn't find her beneath

the bulged-down roof. Justin and Timmy,

they looked to me. They didn't understand

I was not in charge. I'd always been

their only God. They looked to me.

They wanted me to lift them up

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and wipe them clean, to mend
with tenderness their shattered bodies.
But I was pinned in place. Blood
started seeping from Justin's
mouth. Timmy never spoke again.
And then I knew everything: how we
were going to die and how it didn't
really matter in the scheme of things.
My babies' suffering wouldn't matter.
It was a board game of gigantic
proportions. Our tokens
had been shaken out on the playing board
at 5:04 pm on the 17th of October
in the year of our Lord, 1989.

My baby was the last
one to go. *And the last*
shall be first. I hope
it's true. My children
dead around me,
I couldn't think of anything to do
but sing the lullabies I sang

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when they were infants in their cradles
(Insert lullaby lyrics here singing)
You are my sunshine . . . my only sunshine
You make me happy when skies are gray
and I was sending them away
to oblivion for the night.

(Unknown)
I couldn't believe it
when I heard this little voice
singing.
You'll never know dear, how much I love you
Please don't take my sunshine away.
The voice was coming from a dark blue
Toyota squashed almost flat.
When I shone the flash over it,
I could see the dark pool of blood
beneath. In the dark, I could
smell it. I yelled out, ***Ma'am-***
I'm here to help you, and the song
stopped for a moment. Then a voice,
not little at all, harder than any

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I've ever heard, said from deep in the wreck,
You might as well go away. Nobody
can ever help me again.

(Mary)
People have actually asked me
what I thought about in there,
if I figured I would get out,
if I knew the children were dead.
The answer is: when I knew
the children were dead, I didn't want
to get out, couldn't get out
anyway. I was in there
forever with my three little lambs,
the smell of their blood,
and their dead faces, filled with questions,
looking at me.

It suddenly struck me
that I believed
the unbelievable.

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The freeway had apparently
fallen down on top of us.
My children were dead
and dying. My head was locked
into position to watch that.
The only way to not see
was to close my eyes.
But my baby lived
a long time, I think.
I had to look at him
as long as he survived,
to say those things that mothers
say, *It's OK, Mama's here, it will be*
all right. All the while
I was not exactly remembering
my past, but feeling
the future. It had a shape now.
I knew what I was doing
and what I believed.
I was watching
all three of my children
die. More than ever

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before I believed
in God. He was there
in that car. He caused
it, He saw it. And when
it was over, He'd gotten
what He wanted.
One more fearful
citizen bowed down
and kissed His feet.
And then, goddamnit,
I led my babies right up.
I put their little hands
in His, and delivered them over
for eternity to Him.

(Unknown)
I was at the sink
and drinking my second cup
of coffee when the story
about that woman and her three
dead children came on the news.
I screamed

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when I heard it, the saw
and all. How they had to
blindfold her, what they told her
they were doing.
I screamed about this world
men built.

(Mary)
I never went to college
but I know now there's something
more than this world we see.
Trapped in that car, I felt it
when Timmy, Rose, and Justin
expired. They just left, and for awhile
I went with them. We eased
right out of that wreck
and floated in a void
-- a marvelous dimension –
like big flecks of ash
freed from a fire.
That's why it didn't matter
when they took their bodies.

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They had left them already,
and were part of me again, as they were
to begin with, making me bigger.

Their father came over
from the city for the funeral.
He was drunk and terrified
to look at me. I wasn't drunk
and I wasn't scared. People looked
at me like I was a monster -- dry
eyed and calm. But if they'd
touched me, they would have known:
hard as metal on the outside, empty
as a suit of armor within.

(Unknown)
I can't imagine
going through that.
Can you? Watching
your own kids die.
Life
could never be the same,

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could it? How
could you bear it? How
could you live?

(Mary)
I live somewhere else
now. With them. It's not
in space, not
in time. It's pure
feeling, spread out
like jelly on a warm piece
of bread, sinking down
out of sight, the sweetness
still there, sodden
and hidden.

(Unknown)
Those newscasters
stood in front of the freeway
and broadcast their pithy little
stories every evening while people
were dying inside. Now *that's*

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my definition of indecent.

(Mary)

A preacher came to see me afterwards.
He asked me not to be
so angry, to forgive God,
to try to see it as part
of a plan I could not understand.
I just looked at him and he saw something
in my eyes that scared him: those three
little babies, frightened as bunnies. ***I can't imagine***
your pain, **he finally said.** ***I wouldn't try to.***
Can your affliction bring you closer
to Christ? Can you be with Him
in your suffering? And then I did something
I'll never regret: I laughed
in his face, I brayed like a donkey.

(Unknown)

Like everyone else, I watched it
on television for three straight days.
There was nothing a person like me
could do. The twentieth century
caved in finally. The earth
taught cement a permanent
lesson. Now, it's not
that I'm phobic. It's just
that I've seen postmodern light.
We're all insane
to live this way.

(?)

The earth settled.
The waters calmed.
The planet twirled in the heavens
unconcernedly
again.

(Mary)

When the priest raises
the pale white Host
something really does
happen if you want
to believe. If you don't,

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it might still happen
anyway. Right?
Your past wiped out
by the force of the mystery.
The future emerging
from one huge moment . . .

Once, at a student play
in seventh grade,
the whole backdrop collapsed
with the wheezy singing
of nails being forced
from cheap wood. Frayed ropes
dangling like live snakes
and sawdust rising in a smoky haze.
When the scene settled,
Reality was where
it had always been:
right *there,* lurking
behind the drapes:
a cinderblock wall
painted pale green and a red door

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marked Emergency Exit chained shut.
For once, nothing
but an empty stage separated
me from It. I *was*
It, and It was this:
several million tons of concrete roadway
and steel beams smashed
down on top of
approximately 274 live human beings
when the San Andreas Fault flexed a tiny muscle.
39 died, including my children. I
survived. Hundreds
took part in the rescue effort.
The rest of you -- Christ
have mercy -- watched on TV.

The red door
was chained shut.
We went through it
anyway.

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
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Song lyrics to You are My Sunshine can be found here
https://www.lyricsondemand.com/miscellaneouslyrics/lullabylyrics/youaremysunshinelyrics.html

"You Are My Sunshine" is a song copyrighted and published by Jimmie Davis and Charles Mitchell in 1940. It has been recorded by more than 350 artists, and translated into 30 languages.

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